The overnight train journey to Jammu was uncomfortable because of the hot and muggy weather. From there it was a gruelling three days' journey by road to Tangdhar, a distance of about 250 kilometres. The movement beyond Jammu was in a controlled convoy system, with scheduled halts at the transit camps en route. After a night halt in a beautiful transit camp by the side of the turbulent Chenab river at Ramban, I reached Srinagar the following day.

The rundown transit camp at Srinagar could be made out even at a distance of half a kilometre, by the bluish grey smoke emanating from the coal-fired 'bukharies' being lit in the evenings, particularly during the winter. The fine soot of these heating devices had, over the years, coated everything in sight black. The faces and hands of the bearers and other workers in the camp had been darkened by the smoke. It reminded me of the poor chimney sweeps I had read about, while in school. Pollution and degradation of the environment at its best, I mused.

The next day, after a tedious and tiring journey on an even more potholed road, the convoy halted at the logistics base for the troops serving on the LoC. During the winter the journey beyond had to be on foot or by helicopter due to the enormous amount of snow on the Shamsabari range. Because of the danger of avalanches, the next stage of the journey, to the Nastachun Pass and beyond into the valley of Tangdhar, had to be undertaken at night. The steep snowy slopes were comparatively stable during that period.

After a refreshing mug of tea at the pass, we proceeded ahead and reached the Battalion HQ in the evening. I was welcomed by the commanding officer, Lieutenant Colonel J.S. Dhillon. The next day, I was formally interviewed by him and 'dined in'. From the Battalion HQ to my company piquet it was a strenuous uphill trek of about two hours. My post was at an altitude of about 8000 feet. I was received there by the subedar sahib and shown around. The barbed-wire fence and the skull-and-bones warning boards inside the minefield indicated the LoC. The proximity of the adversary could not be taken lightly.